

Episode 36: Once Upon a Time... (27) – The Long Battle Over "Colour Direction" Credits, Part 1

The mornings and evenings have gotten quite cold, and even Tokyo's autumn leaves have finally settled down. The trees in the park in front of my house have completely shed their leaves over the past few days, taking on a distinctly winter appearance.

When it's not raining, I basically commute by bicycle the 10 kilometres from my home in Nakano to the studio in Oizumi. During this season, it gets cold, so I'm thoroughly equipped for winter. The morning commute isn't too bad, but since I come home late at night, sometimes in the early morning hours, it gets absolutely freezing cold.

My basic style is a new-material long-sleeve T-shirt and fleece on top. Over that, a Gore-Tex parka with a fleece neck warmer around my neck. On my hands, cycling gloves. Below, boxer shorts and more new-material "high-tech long underwear," plus mountaineering long pants.

These new-material underwear items are absolutely amazing. They convert sweat moisture into heat (?), so they're warm, and they let excess sweat escape, keeping the skin feeling smooth and dry. Pretty good! At the studio where it's warm, I work just in that underwear. Oh, of course I put on pants and such for the lower half (laugh).

There's just one drawback. This underwear is body-conscious wear that fits tightly to the body, so it naturally reveals all your body lines completely. Especially around the belly area, it's a bit... bulging.

Ah... I really need to work harder at cycling... (crying).

Well then.

Today's topic is about staff credits.

Most productions have staff credits in both the opening and ending.

First, the opening credits feature the people responsible for the overall production—the "core" staff, so to speak. Planning, production, original work, screenplay, music, character design, chief animation director, art director, colour design (色彩設計), photography director, sound director, and recently CG director, plus the director—in TV series, that's the series director—and so on. This varies between theatrical films, TV works, and OVAs, but that's roughly the format.

The ending credits list the individual staff who worked on the main production. Key animation, in-between animation, animation checking, colouring, colour direction (色指定), finishing inspection, special effects, backgrounds, photography, CG, editing, recording, sound effects, music selection, setting production, assistant director, production management, casting, publicity, cooperating companies in various areas, and so on. In the case of Toei Animation (東映アニメーション), the script supervisor also joins. For TV productions, each episode's screenplay, direction, animation director, and art director are also included.

Now, I'm not certain about other companies, but at Toei Animation, especially for theatrical works, there's an established rule about credits. That is: "Names credited in the opening are, in principle, not credited in the ending."

So what happens is this: in recent theatrical works where I've handled both colour design and colour direction, when my name is credited in the opening, it doesn't appear in the ending. I argued, "But I'm also doing colour direction, so put me in the ending under 'Colour Direction,'" but it was still no good (bitter laugh). So for both *CLANNAD* and *Digimon Savers THE MOVIE: Ultimate Power Burst Mode Activated!!*, my name only appears in the opening.

But you know, animation directors get their names listed under key animation too. Hmm... mysterious.

This "rule" is also partially applied to TV productions. In the recently aired *The Kindaichi Case Files SP*, the first episode "Opera House: The Final Murder" had someone else handling colour direction, so her name appears in the ending under "Colour Direction." But for "The Vampire Legend Murder Case," which I handled for colour direction, there's no "Colour Direction" credit in the ending.

Well, for this *Kindaichi SP*, since it follows the style of standalone theatrical productions, that's how it goes. But for the currently airing *GeGeGe no Kitaro*, in principle, colour designer Itasaka-san has been handling all the colour direction for each episode single-handedly, so there's also no "Colour Direction" credit in the ending. Until now, that is.

However, there was a staff member who got caught up in this rule. From episode 35, one colour director newly joined *GeGeGe no Kitaro*, but since they'd been going without "Colour Direction" credits for so long, the person in charge didn't notice the change and forgot to include the credit. So the colour direction for *GeGeGe no Kitaro* episode 35 was done by Kobioki-san.

Also, with a slightly different meaning, there's the currently airing *Hataraki Kids: My Ham-gumi*. This production also has my name listed as colour designer. In this case, I'm handling the main colour design, but the individual episode colour design is handled by Toyonaga-san, who's credited under colour direction. So this is another pattern that exists.

Now, regarding these "Colour Direction" and "Colour Design" credits—while Toei productions nowadays normally credit colour design and colour direction, when I started working over 20 years ago, neither "Colour Design" nor "Colour Direction" were credited.

As I've written before, at the time, Toei Doga (now Toei Animation) had a system where the art department had major decision-making authority over everything colour-related, with the art staff determining both character colour design and special colouring direction. So we were "inspectors," and while we were actually doing colour direction and colour design, we were positioned as a department that inspected the finished colouring.

So in the ending credits of productions, theatrical works were divided into "Tracing," "Colouring," and "Inspection," but TV productions lumped everyone together under "Finishing."

When I joined Toei Doga, I thought "Well, I guess that's how it is," but after experiencing several productions, I began to think "Is this really right?" Sure, we were doing "inspection," but the work of "colour direction" had actually become the main job in terms of balance.

While the art department was still giving initial colour instructions, all the work from that point on was handled by us. Most importantly, the job of putting colour direction into each and every cut—this work was what controlled the overall cel output, and we had a kind of pride in that. It seemed wrong that this work wasn't credited with the proper terminology that described what it actually was.

And so, the long battle over "Colour Direction" credits began...

(07.12.11)